Why does this matter? For one thing, Indian women are living longer. Life expectancy has risen from 66.4 years in 2005 to around 73.6–74.5 today. "Women today are living longer than ever before," affirms Dr Anita J. Shah, a Surat-based gynaecologist and president of the Indian Menopause Society, "and nearly one-third of their lives may be spent after menopause." Yet neither the women themselves nor the Indian healthcare system seem prepared for it.

It matters for another reason, too: menopause is not a one-time event but a prolonged biological transition. Its symptoms begin years before the final menstrual cycle and continue long after. While commonly associated symptoms such as hot flashes, night sweats and mood swings are widely recognised, menopause also affects cardiovascular, metabolic, bone and cognitive health. Delayed diagnosis and treatment allow silent damage to accumulate.



> **"DOCTORS TODAY ARE REPORTING THAT MORE WOMEN ARE COMING IN WITH MENOPAUSAL SYMPTOMS AT YOUNGER AGES THAN EARLIER"**
>
> **DR ANITA J. SHAH**
> *Gynaecologist; President, Indian Menopause Society*

A Pocketful of Causes

The reasons for early or premature menopause have as much to do with biology as with lifestyle and socio-economic reasons. There is genetics, to begin with. So, when your mother menopaused could well dictate the age at which you menopause. Then, there is the age of menarche, a woman's first period. An early onset could herald early menopause too, given the faster depletion of ovarian reserves. Reproductive history also matters. Pregnancy temporarily pauses ovulation, preserving ovarian follicles. Women who have had children—particularly at certain intervals—may menopause later, while nulliparity—or not having had children—could trigger earlier onset.

Socio-economic factors can influence menopause as well, since education, income and geography influence both awareness and nutrition. So, women from low-income, uneducated, rural backgrounds may face undernutrition, low body mass index, anaemia and metabolic stress, all of which could affect their ovarian health. Urban women may have the opposite problem: despite greater awareness, they may be prone to stress, pollution, smoking, alcohol and poor dietary habits.

To understand what early or premature menopause does to a woman's body, a quick biology lesson may be in order. Menopause is the biological phenomenon when ovaries stop releasing eggs and producing key hormones. Clinically, it is confirmed after 12 consecutive months without a menstrual period. But the transition—perimenopause—can begin up to eight years earlier. Women begin experiencing the first symptoms, with periods starting to get irregular and the body experiencing a variety of symptoms from joint and muscular discomfort, physical and mental exhaustion to irritability and forgetfulness. Some of these symptoms persist through menopause before the body enters the post-menopausal phase for the rest of a woman's life.

But even as the storm in a woman's body subsides, the transition often leaves her with lasting damage, such as brittle bones or cardiovascular complications. And that is because menopause deprives a woman of one crucial life force—oestrogen. It may be known primarily as the 'sex hormone', but oestrogen's job description is far wider. It regulates metabolism, supports insulin sensitivity, moderates stress responses, preserves muscle mass and helps maintain bone density. It also supports gut health, reduces systemic inflammation, and contributes to skin integrity and cognitive function.

Oestrogen Anxiety

As oestrogen levels fall, metabolic changes follow. Insulin fluctuations, elevated cortisol and slower metabolism cause fat to begin accumulating around the abdomen. Muscle mass declines. Inflammation rises, triggering joint pain and cognitive issues. Cholesterol levels increase, raising cardiovascular risk.

WHAT IS MENOPAUSE?

Menopause is a biological phenomenon in a woman's life when her ovaries stop releasing eggs and producing key hormones. Clinically, it is confirmed after 12 consecutive months without a menstrual period. But the transition—perimenopause—can begin up to eight years earlier.

VARIOUS STAGES OF MENOPAUSE

The average menopause age in India is 47 years, with symptoms beginning 5–10 years earlier.

↘ Perimenopause ***(Usually begins at ages 40–45)***

- **Oestrogen levels begin fluctuating**
- **Periods become irregular**
- **Sleep problems, anxiety and fatigue may begin**
- **Weight and mood changes appear**

↘ Menopause

- **Confirmed after 12 months without a period**
- **Hormone levels decline permanently**
- **Symptoms may peak for some women**

↘ Postmenopause

- **Symptoms may ease for many women**
- **Risks for bone loss, heart disease and metabolic changes increase**